Project Report

Cybercrime Awareness & Prevention

Course	CSE0001 - Digital Literacy
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Case Study:
UPI Spoofing and QR Code Scams

In my research as a Student Digital Ambassador, I focused on **UPI Spoofing**, a rapidly growing threat in 2026. Scammers use fraudulent applications that mimic the user interface of popular UPI wallets (like GPay or PhonePe) to show a fake "Payment Successful" screen. This trick is often used against students selling items online or local vendors. Another common tactic is the **QR Code Scam**, where victims are tricked into scanning a code to "receive" money, but in reality, scanning and entering a PIN only *authorizes a deduction* from their own account.

8-Tip Prevention Checklist

To protect yourself and your classmates from these financial threats, follow these essential safety rules:

1. **PIN is only for Sending:** Never enter your UPI PIN or scan a QR code to *receive* money.
2. **Verify the Recipient:** Always double-check the name displayed on your app screen before hitting 'Pay'.
3. **Use Official Apps Only:** Never download "screen-sharing" or "remote access" apps (like AnyDesk) on the instructions of a stranger.
4. **Check Bank SMS:** Confirm that money has actually been credited via your bank's official SMS or app, not just by looking at a sender's screenshot.
5. **Decline 'Collect' Requests:** Be wary of unexpected notifications asking you to "Approve" a payment request.
6. **Secure Your Device:** Use biometric locks and Two-Factor Authentication (2FA) for all financial and social media accounts.
7. **Limit Daily Transactions:** Set a sensible daily limit on your UPI app to minimize potential losses if a breach occurs.
8. **Report Immediately:** If fraud occurs, call the **National Cybercrime Helpline at 1930** or visit **cybercrime.gov.in** within the "Golden Hour" to freeze the transaction.
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Reflection

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Researching UPI fraud was a significant eye-opener for me. As a Computer Science student specializing in **Gaming Technology**, I considered myself tech-savvy, but I realized how sophisticated social engineering has become in 2026. Scammers don't just use technical glitches; they exploit a student's sense of urgency or lack of experience with digital payments.

One major habit I am changing is my level of caution when scanning QR codes in public spaces or while using online marketplaces. I've also shared the **1930 helpline** details with my hostel batchmates,

as many were unaware of the "Golden Hour" for reporting fraud. This task reinforced that being a Digital Ambassador isn't just about building profiles; it’s about maintaining the vigilance required to protect our financial identities. Digital literacy is our first and strongest line of defense against these evolving threats.